

Classical Greek sculpture

During their Classical period, the Greeks achieved new heights in art, architecture, theatre and philosophy. The era began with a Greek victory over Persia in 480 BCE. Confident and with a new sense of unity among the city-states, artists began to try creating lifelike forms. The period became known as Greece's Golden Age. For the first time, artists observed and tried to replicate nature as realistically as possible. In sculpture, implied movement was introduced, as in *Discobolus*, a life-sized statue of an Olympic athlete by Myron, c.450 BCE.

Greek art reached a height of perfection during this period. A massive building programme began with the Parthenon, an imposing expression of harmony and balance, overseen by the sculptor Phidias. His style is characterized by a lightness of touch and attention to detail. Some of the greatest free-standing sculpture of the period was created by Polykleitos, a rival of Phidias. Praxiteles developed sculpture even further, skilfully expressing movement, balance, textures and emotion.



Roman copy of the *Discobolus* of Myron (original c.450 BCE)